

1. WAR

It's interesting what can be gleaned from takeout orders. Great men need food, as do the worker bees that buzz about declaring war. They slurp the same gruel and die on the same earth, because death has no eyes for mortal affairs and thus takes equally. Death is the fairest thing of all, so beautiful that not even light dares near her, and the thin, flagrant line between hand and head is marked for her sake alone, for it is a fact that she would go out of business without sufficient ammunition.

Anyway, the orders. The orders. The notion of a nation's fate lying in the hands of one man is not entirely correct. While he does make the final decision, his subordinates are tasked with countless importances along the way— steaming their suits, ensuring that these suits shine brighter than the pitch centre of the heart, running, preaching like little gods— and of course, ordering takeout.

Figures rise and local businesses rejoice when the horde of steamed fabric pocket-squares assembles. Logically they are one machine, one fattened body transferring his nutrients to the rest, but from the aforementioned 'greatness' conjecture, there must be some sort of separation between the great and the lesser-than. Consequently (to solidify natural distinctions, as God knows 'greatness' means anything more than having a natural propensity for it) each man of differing greatness must order his own takeout.

Catch you this drift? The secretary of defence wants honey walnut shrimp and black pepper chicken. His secretary, assumed in usual bureaucratic fashion to be named 'the secretary of the secretary', orders pizza instead and distributes the spoils among starving baby bird heads; all bald, grey, or black from sweat. They work hard, and they are slim. Unsurprisingly. A great proportion of calories are burnt while standing completely still, rubbing chins over papers emblazoned with blood-red stamps. A proportion comparable to running a marathon. War or war, they mutter, difficult indeed— and to the same finish line.

War is the apex of all things; the god that turns one economic cog-wheel, then the other, then the continuous track that flattens three dimensions into two. Delivery men pray to be born good and holy, and yet even they suffer. The heart's core, dug clean through in hopes of finding intrinsic goodness, is nothing special at all; filled with fast food and pepperoni slices, dirty oil bubbles and caustic gas.

Existence may only permit existence if one group removes another. Distilled to their essentials, removal and being are young things borne of conflict, which began long before the human spirit came into itself, and thereby waits for each and every step forward. Justice is not the advantage of the stronger; so war must exist for war's sake, and bodies must litter the steps of the lawn, piled high as pizza boxes, or there is no point to the gamble. Struggling against fate, the secretary senior concludes, is a Sisyphean task, and succumbing to the basest measures is all one can (and should) do rather than preaching morals that escape empirical testing— for their lack of corporeality, compared to war at least, saps them of all truth. There

are three truths; those being the button on his desk and the steaming box at his side. And greatness. Two more seconds, and ten million bodies will explode somewhere far-off.

Takeout orders hold no significance in the grand scheme of things. That being said, they do alert line cooks of geopolitical disturbances and remind them that any moment, they might disappear entirely; that their fates sit cradled in real mens' hands, great or not. The secretary and his secretary and the endless chain of secretaries dangling from their arms have long since succumbed to the old urge, abandoning fallen gods for new. They appear to think more, yes, know more— and take on higher, fresh-pressed suits— but death has no eyes for mortal affairs. Death takes equally. She and war engage in an intimate betting affair wherein both parties win, regardless of the outcome, and she and takeout orders are good friends.

2. FAMINE

The woman sits, hunched under the moon. A floodlight sits on her straw-head, lighting the crown as if she is a ghost. The curve of her back is ridged, jutting out at regular angles, shoulder blade angel wings, the delicate print of ribs from behind, dress so thin that it all shows, no matter what she has covered. White as a mourning shroud. She focuses on the patch of wetness beneath her. Hands buried in the grains. Rain came only hours ago, to bless the garden, but this plot holds no plants. Her hunger forgoes taste.

The woman's hair trails over her shoulders and to the ground, and her arms work in careful rhythm. One-two, one-two. She brings up handfuls of mud, lifts them to her mouth open like a baby bird and swallows whole, all the death and hope and chicken-shit of a promised land that has run her dry. Never, not even when she arrived, did she hope to eat well. But this? *This* is degrading.

The woman was once someone. Someone who asked what they'd like of her and what they'd need in a wife; hands soft, unsuited for work. And they scoured her body, the supple give, milky plateau, and said she would do. Now she is here, and she is not sure how to leave, for cost-benefit analysis has failed her and she has grown out of gold-chaser's shoes. Deep in the pit of her stomach is a hungry rumbling.

The woman stuffs her cheeks with wet, slimy sludge. It spills from her lips, staining them blacker than blood, and her brow, every so often, catches rain-weighted soggiess. She gags but does not falter. Hills whisper behind her back. She crouches alone on the plateau; she and the half-hut. She and a place that hasn't the seeds to grow.

The woman licks rocks clean of their coats. Undoes the buttons. The key to beauty is in the minimal, the pursuit of return to a simpler state where pleasures of flesh mean naught. Like a pea plant stretching to the greedy sky, she tips her head back and lets the rocks scratch down her gullet; tumbling, fighting for space below. What remains of her family sleeps on last evening's gristle. She remembers when scraps were not cuts of choice. The small, dying grubs between her teeth taste more of meat than anything else.

The woman has a certain romance about her, in the way she moves and the ghostly, impossible beauty that ties her to these hills. She will die maybe tomorrow, maybe the next, from the wasting disease and she will vomit all she eats, perfume on her breath, and her family will slice her body on the dirty edge of a sickle. They will place her over the fire and sear what little meat she has on the behind, the thighs, the shrunken brain, and sigh. It feels a sin— mental starvation— to do such a thing. They will do it anyway.

The woman heaves. She folds her legs underneath, thin as a deer's, and lays among the old bones of the promised country. *These hills are green in the summer*, they say. *These hills are yours*. Why they lied is a mystery not worth exploring, if a mystery at all— though she still has it in her, burning, to hate herself for leaving jade mountains and sweet water and snow-capped love. Now, she is but a shell among shells; virgin beauty dried up, dead. And she is brittle. Starving. Come undone.

3. CONQUEST

Individuals do not deserve individuality. What we know to be the modern-day 'individual' is a crude construction of capitalistic origin, identity bastardised by external force and words that abstract from the truth, and thought, truly *thinking* for oneself and reflecting on what parts of the soul belong to one alone, is but a dream. Observe the messages that are models of models; first an imitation of reality, then an unashamedly different thing in place of what once existed. A different race.

It is true that individuals were once free, but they have robbed themselves of their own agency and must now contend with whatever reaches them past layers, layers, layers of advertisement, falling further. It is also true that individuals should not be trusted to govern themselves— not after what has arisen. Not if they seek any modicum of prosperity beyond the simulacrum so embedded in their collective consciousness; words, images, and truths conflated. Observe them as a sort of unfortunate case study, refusing intervention at first, falling prey to predisposition, and then at last weeping at the researcher's polished feet. Begging to be saved.

How must they be saved? First, optimization; marking what has been deemed 'individual'. Any predetermined modifiers. Envision bats crawling from the trees and spreading dung among huts— indiscriminate, almost corporate in their efficiency, perfect shadows, only perceptible as they blot out the moon. Next, invasion; the horrid bit where destruction occurs. Essentially, ensuring that individuals exist no longer besides the whole, the hole, in which they reside. Envision pestilence. The stink of rot and sourness, fluids lining the streets like rain-puddles; overburdened hospitals, faces that no longer appear as one or another. How beautiful, when the worst of it closes, they will seem, stripped bare of distinction, naked as the Earth meant. Last, management; because annihilation is *nothing* without the upkeep of robbed land. Envision victory, perusing your stock, and the sensation of brittle brain-cases in your hands; petting the heart through the skull, knowing that any movement might crush it. Such is your absolute power. They will not— cannot— tremble, for even that is not given. Even that is learned.

When shells untie and bright red flesh tugs lose, success has come. Results will know very little (only basic language, their primordial babbling) and move very little, for it is unusual to exist without lived baggage. What must then be imprinted on them is of the utmost significance; a barrier of sorts, a hole through either lobe of the cerebral cortex preventing the intellect from becoming so great as to destroy itself again. This operation requires a careful hand.

As for personal management, which team-builders so often neglect, remember. Power should not be lauded over one another, and should not be spoken or bragged. Braggarts derive power *from* their words; they contribute to the web of misstepped, misguided semantics.

Conquerors, on the proper hand, are careful, ideally wordless so that they are not poisoned, and sightless so that better judgement remains intact.

Pestilence, conquest, as individuals argue nowadays... which matters most? They are two sides of the same coin. Perhaps one side of the same coin. Plainly, both sickness and subduction are means to the same end; reductive procedures that bring bodies and minds together, robbing them of agency and saving them, of course. They beg to be altered, redone, ripped from the copies and copies of copies that so plague their societies; the thoughtless drone that *is* real and made all the more terrifying for it. The point of no return. Individuals were once free, but they are no longer. They will rot and continue biting their own tails like sickly snakes until conquered. Stripped.

4. DEATH

They're rather far-fetched. Aren't they?

Oh, come on. Be honest.

Their heads are high and fat with stupidity; beliefs simple and sad; minds beyond reach. The mongerer, the storyteller, the teacher... all young, none prepared to practise what they preach. Worse than warring politicians and perhaps even blinder.

Most often they fail to see what lies ahead. So let me explain, lest you suffer the same. What always lies ahead, without fail, is *I*. Your truest trusted confidant.

I have existed since the beginning, and I am necessary in order to begin, for without a marker there is no start. A marker must stand at some end, otherwise absent of position. I am a tad weary and a tad slow, but welcome wherever my shadow reaches.

My practice is natural. Beautiful. Plainly stated without fanfare and embellishment and the graphic turns of phrase they so often use, like one thing stealing another's skin. I wear no costumes unless the people demand them of me, in which case I become an empty home, or a changed face in the precise reflection of a lake; an exploding star packaged into body-size, or the slow beep and burn of a carbon monoxide detector. Soft as minnows making their way through the underwater brush, moving as someone somewhere once did. Moving as hair's ghost. I am versatile when the need arises.

Mostly, though, I *am*.

Times were good when others feasted on my blessing. I never meant to change face. Death, word laid naked for you now, is not haint-craft; nothing morbid. Specific instances may be tragic and unjust, but the *concept* holds no particular responsibility. I blame those who use it as a weapon. Those who deliver it with weapons, too. So like and unlike the others.

I have ghosted halls full of flowers and nauseatingly sweet film in the air, fit to burst with chatter; fruits and garlands and ribbons circling cared-for portraits. I have also ghosted boxes under six feet of dirt, since oftentimes I am too late for the visitation. Some keep their dead like secrets. It is a difficult thing.

I have come around to sit before time, and before you, and before the rest, and I guide their paths nestled in my gentle hand, and I love them for what they are but no more. Never more. I watch as the suit-calloused forms harden, the women starve with stomachs full of dirt, and the world abrades. I am, of course, waiting for them. I claim homes burnt, and take them and make them mine. I cleanse caked, soft faces. Formless, nameless bodies. There I see beyond the pressions of life, and they become children again. Innocent or not.

The others only care about processes. They obsess over destruction and the journey; especially the gloating afterglow. They'll lap it up, pain and rot and whatnot, and spread doomsayings like funeral flowers before I have even arrived. I am more partial to the holistic.

So men are born for war, and starved wings are beautiful, and no one should be anyone. Even in a world where peace lives yet, much too early for the great assembly; where leaves, washed dark green from rain, drip their holy water, and the wind asks questions, I hear its breath as if my own. Even in a world where the dead are no longer loved. I love them, and I love all the world under my sight. What the others do not understand is, perhaps, the essence of apocalypse;

The last cry will not be war as they expect, and it will not be violent. Their chase began among bright chains of stars, and a hard push outward, and time before leaders amassed force; one small sliver of time from which I emerged. Following the round edge, the globe, chronology as a circular thing, any conclusion should be the same. Hard, quick. An explosion of grief and hope and beginning.

You. That is you.

Now I speak directly to the face on the other side of the veil, and that is you too. How would you like them— the horsemen, I mean— to be dealt with? Killed, their stories too? Rotting on Earth, cursed to forever haunt its lands?

It might be best to wait. If you wouldn't mind. You have done very well already and I hope, when I do come around, that my coming will be a gift. I hope that when we meet, you will dream this again and speak even stranger things. Order takeout. Bathe in the moonlight.

Marvel at what your mind, tiny yet mighty, may one day build— and how strange it will appear falling from grace. It was no pleasant dream that birthed the body.